

It has been estimated that in 1 CE, the great classical civilizations of Eurasia—Greece, Rome, Persia, India, and China—contained half the world's population of 250 million. These were more than formidably well-organized states and empires, with expansive, military, and materialistic ambitions. They were repositories of learning in the sciences and arts

alike, and originators of great political systems—democracy in Greece, Confucianism in China—that have reverberated across the centuries. They also gave rise to a series of global religions—Buddhism, Judaism, and Christianity. Elsewhere, in Central and South America, Africa, and Japan, new civilizations were also emerging.

450 BCE

400 BCE

300 BCE

200 BCE



▲ Detail from Parthenon frieze

c. 450
Athenian power at its peak. Celtic La Tène culture emerges in Central Europe; Celts expand east and south and into British Isles. Steppe nomads buried at Pazyryk and Noin-Ula in Siberia.

c. 400
Ironworking in Korea. Carthage dominates west Mediterranean. Celts settle northern Italy. Moche culture in Peru. In Central America, final phase of Olmec civilization, but Zapotecs flourish in Monte Albán.



▲ School of Athens (Renaissance view by Raphael)



◀ Seleucid bronze

c. 290
Euclid's *Elements* sets out principles of geometry.
c. 287
Chinese states begin "Great Wall."
c. 286
Qin expansion begins in China.

c. 300
Hopewell culture develops in northeast North America. First Celtic states in Europe. Alexander's empire partitioned and ruled by Seleucid, Antigonid, and Ptolemaic dynasties.

▼ Ashoka's stupa at Sanchi, India

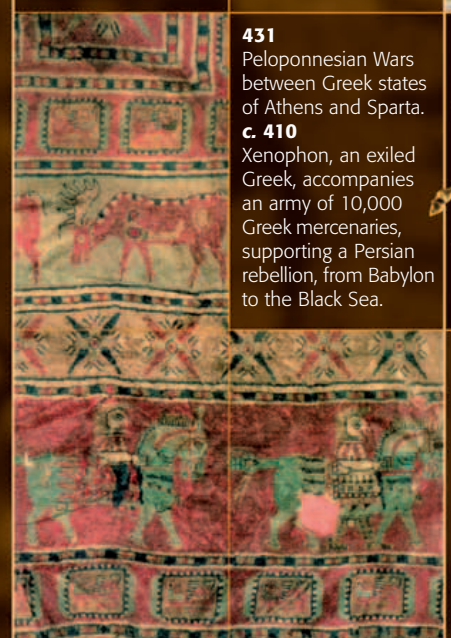
273
Ashoka ascends Indian throne; embarks on imperial conquests.
272
Tarentum, leading Greek city in Italy, falls to Rome.
264–241
Rome and Carthage fight First Punic War.



c. 181
End of Mauryan dynasty, India.
168
Rome expands in eastern Mediterranean.
165
First official exams for Chinese civil servants.
c. 150
Great Serpent Mound constructed in Ohio.



▲ Carthaginian coin



▲ Pile carpet from Pazyryk tomb, Siberia

448
In Athens, construction of second Parthenon begins to replace that destroyed by Persians.
443
"Golden Age" of Athens under Pericles.

431
Peloponnesian Wars between Greek states of Athens and Sparta.
c. 410
Xenophon, an exiled Greek, accompanies an army of 10,000 Greek mercenaries, supporting a Persian rebellion, from Babylon to the Black Sea.



◀ Scythian horseman

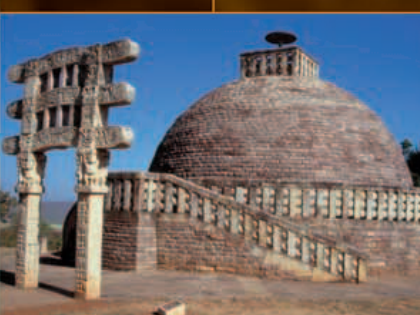
390
Celts sack Rome.
384
Plato completes *The Symposium*.
370
Eudoxus of Cnidus's theory of planetary movement determines the length of a year.

▼ Alexander the Great



c. 360
Crossbow used in Chinese warfare.
359–338
Phillip II extends Macedonian power.
c. 350
Beginnings of Nazca culture in Peru.
336
Alexander succeeds Phillip II of Macedonia.

331
Battle of Gaugamela: Persian Empire falls to Alexander; Alexandria founded, Egypt.
323
Death of Alexander.
321
Chandragupta Maurya founds Mauryan Empire, India.



262
Ashoka allegedly converts to Buddhism.
250
Rome controls Italian peninsula.
c. 246
King Tissa of Sri Lanka converts to Buddhism.
236
Carthaginians conquer parts of Iberia (Spain).



221
China united by first Qin emperor, Qin Shi Huang.
218–201
Second Punic War.
206
Qin empire succeeded by Han dynasty under Liu Bang.
◀ Qin Shi Huang's terra-cotta army



149–146
Rome crushes Carthage in Third Punic War; creates province of Africa in its place; absorbs Greece. Mithridates lays foundation of Parthian Empire. Nomads related to the Scythians invade Bactria.

▲ Roman relief depicting sacrifice to god Mars